process in Myanmar put the government and the Tatmadaw in different roles. The quasi-civilian government acted as a negotiating institution between two key stakeholders of the peace process: the Tatmadaw and the EAGs.

Coming during a political transition, the peace talks have been fragile. The talks have sometimes produced promising deals between the Tatmadaw and the EAGs. At other times, disputes between the Tatmadaw and ethnic leaders pertaining to political and security issues have seriously impeded talks. Such political and security issues range from the country's internal domestic affairs — such as heated discussions of "federalism", and "demobilize, disarm, reintegration" (DDR) — to the country's diplomatic affairs, such as different preferences between the military and EAGs on choices of international observers as foreign witnesses to sign a nationwide ceasefire agreement.

Nevertheless, to the surprise of many scholars and political observers, the Thein Sein government continued to manage its hold on the fragile peace process until the end of its administration in 2015. As a major milestone of the process, the government signed a ceasefire deal with the Tatmadaw and eight EAGs just a month prior to the November 2015 general election, while inviting seven other EAGs, which did not sign at this time, to continue joining the process.

How did the Myanmar transitional government sustain the peace process despite political and security constraints? Analysts have offered different explanations. Attention has been paid to both the characteristics of leaders and of institutions. Some analysts and intermediaries closer to the president's office, for instance Government Chief Negotiator Aung Min (2015) and Aung Naing Oo (2014), describe the current peace negotiations as a result of the agency determinant, focusing on the abilities of the leadership. Aung Naing Oo (2014, p.1) argues that the political leadership provided by President Then Sein at the political opening served as "a turning point" for the current peace process to become successful. However, this assessment fails to account for variations in the president's personal influence over the Tatmadaw.

On the other hand, Ashley South (2014, p. 1) argues that any future government would be less likely "to accord the same degree of privilege and credibility to ethnic armed groups as the current military-backed regime has done". South's explanation focuses on institutional determinants, noting the existence of the Thein Sein government backed by the military. South implies that being a military-backed regime, the Thein Sein government enjoyed the support from the Tatmadaw, which allowed it to grant more privileges to EAGs and have more credibility than a future government would. This argument